

Create.IT - Group Design C Supporting Document

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1. Introduction

This document explains how our Create.IT prototype satisfies the requirements of Group Design C. It covers:

- The problem statement provided by the client.
- The UX research conducted on three existing course platforms and the guidelines derived from that research.
- The Peak-End Rule and its relevance to the assignment.
- The specific design decisions made to satisfy the client's brief.
- How the final prototype was implemented technically.

The reader is encouraged to open the prototype alongside this document and follow the flow described in Section 5 to see each design decision in context.

2. The Client and the Problem Statement

The client's statement was:

"I see there are a lot of websites out there that does the same thing as ours, but theirs are just so... bland. I need ours to pop! Whether it's them checking out a course, pushing a button, or finishing a course, something needs to stand out!"

The client's concern is not functional. The concern is emotional and memorial: the platform needs to leave users with a positive, memorable impression, particularly at the three moments the client names:

1. When the user checks out a course.
2. When the user presses a button (any meaningful action within the platform).
3. When the user finishes a course.

These three moments are exactly the moments that the **Peak-End Rule** identifies as most important to how an experience is remembered. This shaped the entire design direction for Group Design C.

3. Research and Design Guidelines

3.1 UX Evaluation Method

To ground the design decisions in evidence, three UX evaluations were conducted on existing online learning platforms: Clickup, Coursera, and Udemy. Each evaluation used a shortened User Experience Questionnaire (UEQ) with four participants and a task-based walkthrough of the site.

Full details of each evaluation are available in the three accompanying UX reports. A synthesized set of design guidelines, drawn from all three reports, is presented in Section 3.3 of this document.

3.2 Key Findings from the Three Reports

3.2.1 Clickup

- **Strengths (highest UEQ scores):**
 - Supportive, easy to use, and efficient.
 - Simplified user interface with little room for confusion.
 - Prominent side-panel to-do list and the progress bars on course content screens serve as a relatively strong functional and emotional peak.
- **Weaknesses (relatively lowest UEQ scores):**
 - Not exciting, not particularly interesting, and not inventive.
 - No satisfying end state. Task completion produces little emotional payoff.
 - Design is functional but emotionally flat.

- **Peak-End Observation:** The to-do list and the green check that appears when a progress bar reaches 100% are the peaks. Completion of tasks is the end, but the platform provides no ceremony around it, so the memory of using the site is utility rather than accomplishment.
- **Design Guidelines from this Report:**
 1. Make completion status visible and impactful.
 2. Provide immediate feedback for user actions.
 3. Use interaction feedback to reinforce task completion.
 4. Make milestones memorable.
 5. Use visual emphasis strategically, not decoratively.

3.2.2 Coursera

- **Strengths (highest UEQ scores):**
 - Easy, efficient, and clear to navigate.
 - Strong course pages and enrolment procedure.
 - Enrolment confirmation and progress bar at the end of the flow provide a sense of reward.
- **Weaknesses (lowest UEQ scores):**
 - Not exciting, not interesting, and not leading edge.
 - Course pages are cluttered with pop-ups, an AI assistant that occupies half the screen, and a scrolling bar that obscures content.
- **Peak-End Observation:** The clutter on course pages creates a negative peak that dominates the user's memory of the experience. The end of the enrolment flow is positive but understated.
- **Design Guidelines from this Report:**
 1. Make important user actions visibly noticeable.
 2. Provide clear feedback at each step.
 3. Do not overload any single page with information or actions.
 4. Make course completion feel significant.
 5. Differentiate important moments from routine ones.
 6. Create a final memorable interaction.

3.2.3 Udemy

- **Strengths (highest UEQ scores):**
 - Supportive, easy, efficient, and clear.
 - Clear navigational path with a strong *"Let's start learning"* entry point.
 - Course completion produces a certificate, which gives the user a sense of legitimacy and accomplishment.
- **Weaknesses (lowest UEQ scores):**
 - Not inventive and not leading edge.
 - Recommendations are difficult to view.
 - Overall aesthetic is bland.
- **Peak-End Observation:** The peak is the *"Let's Start Learning"* recommendations section, which sits prominently at the top of the dashboard. The end is the awarding of the certificate, which provides a strong sense of closure and achievement.
- **Design Guidelines from this Report:**
 1. Make course completion feel like an achievement.
 2. Provide clear feedback for major actions.
 3. Use a clear visual hierarchy.
 4. Emphasize milestones as the course progresses.
 5. Create memorable moments throughout the course, not only at the end.
 6. Ensure a clear impression is left upon completion of a course.

3.2.4 Core Insight

The three reports converge on a single point: existing course platforms get the middle right and the ends wrong. All three scored highly on pragmatic quality (easy, efficient, clear, supportive) but middling to low on hedonic quality (exciting, interesting, inventive, leading edge).

Users remember the platforms as useful but not enjoyable, and do not return for the memory of the experience. This is precisely the problem the client is describing when they say the competition is *"bland."*

3.3 Synthesized Design Guidelines

Across the three evaluations, several patterns emerged. The following guidelines are the combined principles that guided the design of the Create.IT prototype:

ID	Guideline	Description & Application in Create.IT
G1	Make critical actions stand out	Buttons that represent meaningful user decisions (enrol, complete, finish) must be visually distinct from routine actions. <i>Applied in Create.IT through primary button styling, hover elevation, and animated pulse on the celebration CTA.</i>
G2	Provide immediate, visible feedback	Every meaningful action must produce a clear response, whether a toast, a state change, or an animation. <i>Applied in Create.IT through toasts on every state change, progress bar pulses on lesson completion, and a full-screen celebration on enrolment.</i>
G3	Design the peaks, not just the middle	The moments that define how users remember the experience are the emotional peaks and the final moment. <i>Applied in Create.IT through the enrolment celebration overlay, the milestone markers on progress bars, and the certificate ceremony.</i>
G4	Never let the end be a non-event	The final state of a user journey must feel like an arrival, not an exit. <i>Applied in Create.IT through the CompletionModal at 100% progress, and the certificate ceremony with confetti, congratulations header, and real download.</i>
G5	Avoid clutter on detail-heavy pages	Coursera's course pages show what happens when everything competes for attention. <i>Applied in Create.IT through progressive disclosure on course details, a clean catalog list, and a collapsible sidebar.</i>
G6	Reward milestones, not just the finish	Long processes without visible progress lose user interest. <i>Applied in Create.IT through milestone markers at 25%, 50%, and 75% on the progress bar,</i>

		<i>and milestone-specific toast messaging at each threshold.</i>
G7	Use visual emphasis strategically	Contrast, size, and animation should be reserved for the moments that matter. <i>Applied in Create.IT through the restrained overall design, with celebratory animations only fired at the three key moments.</i>
G8	Reinforce the sense of progress	Users who can see how far they have come are more likely to continue. <i>Applied in Create.IT through the progress bar, the enrolled courses dashboard, and the "next lesson" indicator.</i>

4. The Peak-End Rule

The Peak-End Rule, referenced in Kahneman et al. (1993), states that users judge an experience primarily by two moments: the emotional peak of the experience, and the end of the experience. The duration and average quality of the experience matter far less than these two moments.

Applied to the client's concerns, this produces three design implications:

1. The three moments the client named (checkout, button press, course completion) are exactly the moments that should be designed for emotional impact.
2. Every other part of the experience should be smooth but not distracting, so that the peaks are not diluted.
3. The end of the user journey must feel like an arrival, not an exit.

The design guidelines from Section 3.3 were formulated with these implications in mind. The implementation in Section 5 shows how each one was realised.

5. Design Implementation

The prototype designs three peak moments and one end moment across the customer journey.

5.1 Peak One: Enrolment Celebration

- Where it appears: When the user completes a demo checkout.
- What happens: A full-screen celebration overlay appears, containing:
 - A canvas-based confetti burst that runs for approximately three seconds.
 - An animated SVG checkmark that draws itself in the centre of the screen.
 - A *"You're in!"* headline that scales into place.
 - The thumbnails of the courses the user just enrolled in, appearing one after another in a staggered reveal.
 - Two buttons: Start Learning (which takes the user to the dashboard) and View Receipt (which takes the user to their purchase history).
- Why this design: The client specifically named *"checking out a course"* as a moment that needs to stand out. The previous state of the prototype simply switched tabs and displayed a toast, which is the same flat experience the client complained about. The celebration overlay makes the moment visually and emotionally distinct from every other interaction in the platform.
- Supporting guidelines: G1, G2, G3, G4, G6, G7.

5.2 Peak Two: Lesson Completion with Milestones

- Where it appears: On the student learning dashboard, when the user presses *"Complete Next Lesson"*.
- What happens:
 - A floating +25% badge rises from the progress bar and fades out.
 - The progress bar briefly brightens and returns to normal.
 - The course card flashes green momentarily.
 - Milestone markers at 25%, 50%, and 75% fill in with a checkmark as the user's progress crosses each threshold.
 - The toast message changes based on the milestone reached:
 - *"First milestone! 25% complete"*
 - *"Halfway there! 50% complete"*
 - *"Almost there! 75% complete"*

- At 100%, a CompletionModal appears with a *"You finished it"* headline, the course thumbnail, and two buttons: Claim Certificate and Continue Learning.
- Why this design: The client specifically named *"pushing a button"* as a moment that needs to stand out. Most platforms treat lesson completion as a data update. By layering animation, milestone feedback, and graduated messages, the platform turns a repeated low-value action into a series of small positive peaks. This also directly addresses the weakness identified in the Clickup report: task completion produced no satisfaction.
- Supporting guidelines: G1, G2, G3, G6, G7, G8.

5.3 The End: Certificate Ceremony

- Where it appears: When the user opens their certificate, either from the CompletionModal at 100% progress or from the *"View Certificate"* button on a completed course in the dashboard.
- What happens:
 - A confetti burst fires as the certificate opens.
 - A congratulations header appears with the user's first name, animated with a subtle shimmer.
 - The certificate frame has a golden shimmer sweep across it as it settles.
 - A "Download" button generates a real PNG of the certificate at $2 \times$ resolution using html2canvas.
- Why this design: The client specifically named *"finishing a course"* as a moment that needs to stand out. The Udemy report identified the certificate as the only positive end state across the three evaluated platforms. By layering ceremony (confetti, congratulations header, shimmer) on top of the certificate itself, the prototype ensures the end of the journey produces a strong, memorable positive impression. The real PNG download makes the certificate tangible rather than a decorative screen.
- Supporting guidelines: G1, G3, G4, G7.

5.4 The Middle: Smooth, Not Memorable

The parts of the platform that are not peaks are deliberately restrained. The catalogue uses a clean list layout. The course detail page uses progressive disclosure so that only the most relevant information is visible at a time. The sidebar collapses to open up

workspace. The design guidelines G5 (avoid clutter) and G8 (reinforce progress) shape these choices.

The reasoning follows directly from the Coursera report: Coursera's course pages have a negative peak caused by clutter, which harms the memory of the whole platform even though the underlying functionality is solid. The Create.IT prototype avoids this by keeping every non-peak surface calm.

6. How the Design Satisfies the Client's Brief

The client asked for three things to stand out: checking out a course, pushing a button, and finishing a course.

1. **Checking out a course:** Satisfied by the enrolment celebration overlay described in Section 5.1.
2. **Pushing a button:** Satisfied by the milestone feedback on lesson completion described in Section 5.2.
3. **Finishing a course:** Satisfied by the certificate ceremony described in Section 5.3.

In each case, the moment is designed as a deliberate emotional peak, and in each case the moment draws on the guidelines derived from the three UX reports. The result is a platform that is not simply functional, but memorable at the specific moments that matter most to how users recall the experience.

7. Conclusion

The Create.IT prototype was designed to satisfy a specific client brief: make the platform pop at three specific moments. The research conducted on Clickup, Coursera, and Udemy showed that existing platforms fail at exactly these moments, and the Peak-End Rule explains why that failure matters so much.

By designing three deliberately memorable peaks (enrolment, lesson completion, course completion) and a strong final moment (the certificate ceremony), and by keeping every other surface calm and uncluttered, the prototype gives users a reason to remember the experience positively, not just to use it functionally.

References

Kahneman, D., Fredrickson, B. L., Schreiber, C. A., & Redelmeier, D. A. (1993). *When more pain is preferred to less: Adding a better end*. Psychological Science, 4(6), 401-405.

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